



TPM Academy Kickoff

Half-Day Orientation • Pre-Week 1

Technical Product Manager Academy

About Me

John Kidd



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- Form the **triads** you'll work with through Week 3's mini-capstone
- Agree on the ground rules: AI policy, notetaker policy, attendance, feedback
- Confirm everyone is technically ready for Monday



This Morning's Shape

Clock	Block	Outcome
09:00 – 09:30	Welcome & Introductions	Faces, names, why-you're-here
09:30 – 10:30	Block 1 — The TPM Role	Shared mental model of the job
10:30 – 10:45	Break	
10:45 – 11:45	Block 2 — Curriculum Tour + Triad Formation	Eight-week map; your triad
11:45 – 12:30	Logistics, Q&A, Week 1 launch	Ready to start Monday



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- For follow-up questions, reach out directly to the instructor

My Pledge to You

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- Use an on-screen timer for breaks and activity timeboxes
- Adapt to accessibility needs — let me know, on or off the record

Activity 1 — Two Truths and a TPM

Format: Full room → pairs • 20 min

- Pair up with someone you've never worked with
- Each of you shares **three statements**: two true, one false — all about your product or engineering experience
- Partner guesses the false one and asks one follow-up question
- We'll surface the most surprising "truth" from each pair when we regroup

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Goal: leave the icebreaker with one new face you can put a story to.

Block 1 — The TPM Role

What you're actually signing up to do



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- Reasons about latency, data shape, dependencies, and trade-offs — not just features
- Negotiates priorities with stakeholders who hold conflicting truths



TPM vs PM vs EM

Product Manager

- What and why
- Customer evidence, market positioning
- Outcome ownership across the product
- Often less technical depth

Technical Product Manager

- What, why, **and feasible how**
- Customer evidence + system constraints
- Often owns API/platform/infra surfaces
- Speaks both languages fluently

Engineering Manager

- How and who
- People, delivery, technical execution quality
- Owns engineering capacity and team health



The Five Sibling Artifacts

By Week 5 you'll have written each of these at least once:

Artifact	Question it answers	Owner of the truth
PRD — Product Requirements Document	What are we building and why?	TPM
TCD — Technical Concept Document	What is the high-level system shape?	TPM + Architect
TMD — Technical Modeling Document	What are the data and component models?	TPM + Tech Lead
SEP — Stakeholder Engagement Plan	Who is impacted and how do we engage them?	TPM
DP — Delivery Plan	How will we ship and measure?	TPM + EM



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- **Hiding behind customer empathy.** Using personas to dodge technical accountability.



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- **Hiding behind customer empathy.** Using personas to dodge technical accountability.
- **Owning every artifact alone.** The five sibling artifacts are *collaborative*, not solo writing exercises.

Activity 2 — "Where Have You Seen a TPM Win or Lose?"

Format: Quartets • 30 min

- Each person writes a 60-second story: a real TPM (or PM doing TPM work) you saw *win* or *lose* a decision
- Read silently around the table — no narration
- The quartet picks **one** story and identifies which failure mode (or its inverse) was in play
- One quartet per readout: 90 seconds each

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Deliverable: a tagged story per quartet, surfaced to the room.



Break

15 minutes — be back at 10:45

Block 2 — Curriculum Tour + Triad Formation

Where this is going, and who you're going with



The Eight-Week Map

Week	Theme	Capstone moment
1	Customer-Centric Foundations	—
2	Strategic Design & Metrics	—
3	Requirements Engineering	Mini-capstone PRD + peer review
4	Technical Architecture & Constraints	—
5	Technical Infrastructure & Modeling	—
6	Stakeholder Alignment & Negotiation	—
7	Agile Delivery & ADO Mastery	—
8	AI Spec Development & Capstone	Real-world capstone + presentations



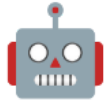
The Capstone Arc

Week 3 Mini-Capstone

- Triad-built PRD
- Running case study: **FieldPulse** (HVAC dispatch SaaS)
- Peer review on Friday — every triad reads every other triad
- AI tools off — honor system

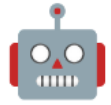
Week 8 Final Capstone

- Real product / problem you bring
- Full set of 5 sibling artifacts
- Friday: 12-minute presentation + Q&A
- AI tools on with validation discipline



The AI Policy in One Sentence

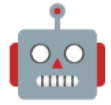
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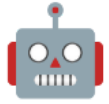
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AI tools are **part of the curriculum, not a shortcut around it** — except Week 3, where they are explicitly off so the muscle of unaided requirements writing gets built.

- Weeks 1, 2, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8 — AI is in scope; validation discipline is required
- Week 3 — AI off in your editor, off in your browser, honor system
- Every AI-assisted artifact gets a **provenance note**: prompts used, what was kept, what was discarded



What You'll Use Day to Day

Full setup instructions are in `setup/TECH-SETUP.md`.



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- **Azure DevOps** — Week 7 only; we'll confirm access before then

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- Triads reshuffle for Weeks 4–8

Activity 3 — Triad Formation + First Commitment

Format: Self-organize → triads • 25 min

- Stand. Find two people with at least one *different* dimension from you: experience level, domain, or home team
- Sit together. You are a triad through end of Week 3
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Deliverable: a named triad and a written commitment, on a single index card.

Logistics, Q&A, Week 1 Launch

The last 45 minutes



Daily Rhythm Starting Monday

Block	Duration
Opening & objectives	0:15
Teaching Block 1 + Activity 1	1:15
Morning break	0:15
Teaching Block 2 + Activity 2	1:15
Lunch	1:00
Teaching Block 3 + Activity 3	1:15
Afternoon break	0:15
Teaching Block 4 + Activity 4 + Wrap	1:30



Feedback & Channels

During the academy

- Daily anonymous pulse — one click, end of day
- Triad-internal: keep it direct, low-stakes
- Direct to instructor: any time, any channel

End of each week

- Friday 15-minute retrospective — what worked / what to adjust
- End-of-week pulse survey
- Adjustments visible by Monday



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- Your triad commitment card

? Open Q&A

Common categories of questions to expect at this point:

- "What if my AI access doesn't work?"
- "What happens if I miss a day?"
- "Can our triad change if it's not working?"
- "How is performance evaluated?"
- "What artifacts do I keep after the academy?"



See You Monday at 09:00

Week 1, Day 1 — AI Fundamentals & Prompting for TPMs